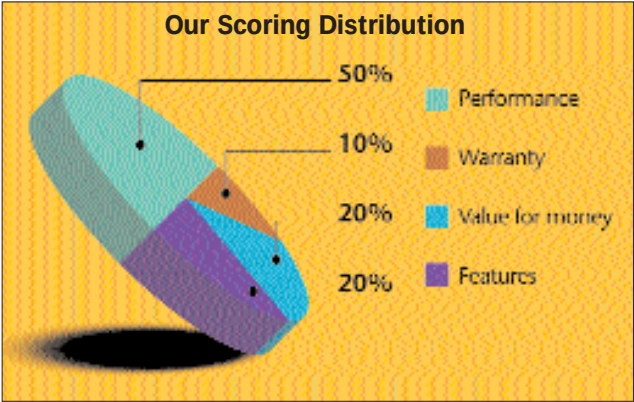


things duly noted and suitably awarded where whether the symbols on the settings buttons were self-explanatory, allowing the user to adjust the settings without consulting the user manual; the presence of Back and Forward keys for the selection of different menus. These can be great advantage when you enter a wrong menu and can get out of it, just by pressing the Back button, instead of being forced to go through the entire menu. The latest monitors come with integrated speakers—some have the speakers built into the same casing, while others are detachable. The monitors that came with their own set of speakers earned more points.

An important matter was that of the monitor base that decided the tilt of the monitor—the more the tilt, the better. The grip of the display was also checked. In the case of LCDs, those that could be wall-mounted afforded more convenience, and hence won more accolades. Since most monitors and graphics cards will be shifting from the VGA cable to the DVI output in a few years, monitors with a DVI output were preferred. The height adjustment of the monitors decided if the displays could be adjusted for maximum comfort. Some LCDs can be rotated vertically—landscape to portrait—this can be boon while reading long Word files or PDFs without the aid of a scroll-wheel mouse.

An often overlooked feature is the user

manual. This mandatory piece of documentation was dissected to see the level of details it contained, if it used diagrams to aid the explanation of the different menus, buttons and functions. It is also helpful if the manual states the technical specifications of the monitor clearly.



CRT Monitors

Test Analysis

17-inch Monitors

The BenQ G774 comes with four blue buttons on its front panel that help in adjusting the OSD menu. This monitor has a bandwidth of 110 MHz, resulting in a flicker free display and supports a highest resolution of 1280 x 1024 at 67 Hz—however, it does not come with a full and flat picture tube (F&FST).

The OSD is quite intuitive and self-explanatory; the buttons are conveniently placed, and offer ease of use along, with a good OSD menu structure. The monitor is a bit bulky and on the heavier side, but comes with a sturdy swivel base with a small foot print. It comes in a plain

vanilla package, and does away with any extras such as USB hubs, speakers or multimedia—an optional USB hub can be purchased separately. It has the requisite manuals and driver disk for installation.

The Samsung Sync Master 753 DFX monitor comes with F&FST, making it an absolute delight to use. The monitor has four buttons on its front for adjusting the various OSD settings, which is intuitive and simple to use.

The latest release from Samsung, the 763 MB, sports an absolute flat screen. The 'MB' stands for Magic Bright, which automatically adjusts the brightness of the monitor according to the application you are using. It has the options of Text, Inter-

Important Standards for Displays

In the world of today, where the usage of computers has increased tremendously, and computing has seeped into almost all industries, prolonged usage is bound to have its repercussions. But have you ever bothered to find out if your monitor complies with the safety norms? Given below is the history of various safety standards that have been accepted by monitor manufacturers.

In 1980, Swedac, a Swedish testing company expressed concern over possible health issues related to monitor, and also about its ergonomics and emission levels. After taking these into consideration, they drew up a standard called the MPR1 [FULL FORM]. Then in 1990, this standard was amended, and a new standard called MPR2 was to be exercised by all the monitor manufacturers. MPR2 ensured a reduction in the emission level, and also a conductive coating on the monitor screen.

A newer standard called TCO92 was invented in 1992 by the Swedish Confederation of Professional Employees. Unlike the MPR2 level, here the emission levels of the monitor were decided by the manufacturers themselves. This standard sets far stiffer levels of emission and required monitors to meet the international EN60950 standard for electrical and fire safety. [HUH? CONTRADICTION].

In 1993, VESA started a new standard called DPMS (Display Power Management Signalling), which set the four monitor

modes—on, standby, suspend and off—at user-defined periods.

Simultaneously in 1993, EPA Energy Star; a power saving standard was made compulsory in USA and was also adopted across Europe. Even though this standard was initiated in 1993, it wasn't implemented till the year 1995.

In 1995, TCO again modified its standards, changed the requirements for visual ergonomics and added a range of conditions to cover environmental issues, including the use of certain chemicals in manufacturing and the recycling of components. TCO95 became the first global environmental labelling scheme. It was more comprehensive than the German Blue Angel label, and more exacting than ISO international standards.

TCO99 is the latest iteration of the standard. It doesn't change the emission levels from the previous versions, but does alter the testing procedures to deal with certain loopholes. This new approval mainly concentrates on improving the visual ergonomics requirements that include better luminance uniformity and contrast. There is also a new requirement that the screen colour temperature adjustment, when present, should be accurate. To reduce eye fatigue caused by image flicker, the minimum refresh rate is increased to 85 Hz for displays of less than 20-inches, with 100 MHz recommended, and a minimum of 75 Hz for displays measuring 20-inches, or greater.